

Chapter 136-1

There were too many instances like this.

Emotions extended from every little detail.

After eating the candy, Xu Qingzhu only thought to ask: "When did you put the candy there?"

"Yesterday." Liang Shi answered.

Because Xu Qingzhu had once cried until she fainted, Liang Shi had desperately messaged Zhao Xuning, asking very discreetly what to do.

Zhao Xuning was silent for a few seconds before replying: 【Low blood sugar.】

Liang Shi then ordered delivery on her phone, having it delivered along with lunch.

So Xu Qingzhu didn't know about it.

And because of that question, Zhao Xuning took the opportunity to get revenge for that day, sending a message to tease Liang Shi: 【Miss Liang, you're quite capable, huh.】

Liang Shi: 【...What else?】

She felt a bit guilty and embarrassed when replying.

Afraid Zhao Xuning would say something more, Liang Shi immediately said: 【Don't say it. I need to save face.】

Zhao Xuning: 【Heh.】

Even through the screen, you could feel Zhao Xuning's sneer.

It was clearly a good quality, but for Liang Shi, it was somewhat embarrassing to talk about.

Zhao Xuning wasn't someone without boundaries either. When it came to other people's private matters, she teased a few times and then let it go, properly educating Liang Shi on the topic.

The educational content could be written down as a checklist, titled: Precautions for Omegas During Heat Periods.

It was clear that Zhao Xuning had done extensive research.

But Zhao Xuning's academic research direction wasn't in this area.

Who exactly she had researched it for went without saying.

But Liang Shi couldn't be bothered to meddle. The person involved wasn't even worried, so no matter how many tricks she pulled, it would be useless.

The drawer held all kinds of candy.

There were fruit hard candies in transparent wrappers, mint candies, and the milk candies that both Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu liked very much.

After eating candy, Xu Qingzhu's mood was noticeably much better. She found a comfortable position lying on Liang Shi's lap, asked Liang Shi for a fruit candy, unwrapped it, and fed it to Liang Shi's mouth.

The milk candy Liang Shi had just eaten hadn't been swallowed yet; her mouth was full of the sweet, rich milk candy taste.

Facing the candy she offered, she shook her head, her agile tongue pushing the candy out as she mumbled: "Haven't finished eating yet."

Xu Qingzhu's brow furrowed slightly. Her face, which had been smiling just moments ago, suddenly fell a bit, and her wet eyes looked over.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's warm fingertips fell below her eyelids, gently caressing as she asked softly: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu turned over, looking away from her.

Even the most oblivious person could tell that Xu Qingzhu was upset.

Liang Shi's hand gently pinched her waist.

Xu Qingzhu was on the thinner side, but with a slight pinch, you could still pinch some flesh.

She didn't know when this habit had developed—probably learned from Xu Qingzhu. But when Liang Shi pinched, she was very measured and could control her strength.

There was only one time when she hadn't controlled her strength well and made Xu Qingzhu cry.

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell like beads from a broken string, crying uncontrollably.

Liang Shi panicked at once and hurriedly apologized to her.

But Xu Qingzhu ignored her. After a moment, warm moisture appeared on the pinched skin.

When the wind blew, it felt cool.

But Liang Shi's movements were gentle, her hair tips lightly brushing over Xu Qingzhu's lower abdomen.

Xu Qingzhu momentarily forgot to cry.

A few minutes later, Liang Shi's fingertips wiped away the moisture from that area, hugging her from behind and admitting her mistake: "Baby, I was wrong."

Xu Qingzhu let out a soft hum.

Only then was this matter put to rest.

But this time, Liang Shi had clearly deliberately restrained her strength. She thought it was nothing.

It was just an intimate little gesture between lovers.

But before long, she felt warm moisture on her leg.

...She was crying again.

Liang Shi picked Xu Qingzhu up, letting her face rest on her shoulder.

An Alpha's body could handle her weight. Liang Shi's hand fell on her hair, coaxing her like a child.

Even more patient and attentive than coaxing a child.

Chapter 136-2

"Baby, why are you crying again?" Liang Shi asked softly.

The tip of her tongue, which had just tasted candy, pressed against Xu Qingzhu's glands and lightly traced over them.

This action carried a hint of placation, as well as a trace of threat.

But for an Omega who had just gone through her heat period, it was still effective.

Especially late at night.

It was just a very subtle movement, yet it made the Omega's body temperature rise.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing only a spaghetti strap short dress.

Even though this was a coastal city, it was still in the north. After the snow, the weather was getting colder, but the heating inside was very warm.

Especially since the two of them had been cooped up at home for several days, with the blanket casually placed to the side—they didn't feel cold at all.

The short dress was plaid, bought by Xu Qingzhu at some unknown time.

Liang Shi had gotten clothes for her from the wardrobe, but she couldn't see in the dark and was in a hurry to carry her to bathe. The pajamas in her closet had all been used up, hanging on the balcony, washed but not yet dry.

She could only randomly find a dress to wear.

Only after putting it on did Liang Shi realize how short that dress was.

But it looked good.

It was a bit like JK style,¹ but not entirely.

Liang Shi couldn't categorize it, so she just generally called it a short dress.

The Alpha's forearms had smooth lines, the powerful type—though slender, they didn't appear weak.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't spoken the whole time, and the room fell quiet.

"Baby~" Liang Shi bit her ear, showing full intimacy.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally said in a muffled voice: "You said only your wife can feed you candy..."

"So." Xu Qingzhu said very logically: "You won't eat the candy I feed you..."

Liang Shi: "?"

She never expected Xu Qingzhu would think in that direction, and immediately explained: "That's because I already had the one you fed me earlier."

Xu Qingzhu still didn't speak, her head buried in her shoulder.

"Wife." Liang Shi said by her ear: "I'll eat it."

"Eat what?" Xu Qingzhu asked in a muffled voice.

Liang Shi: "...Candy."

After a moment, before Xu Qingzhu could make any move, Liang Shi changed her mind first. Before Xu Qingzhu could react, she placed her on the bed.

After a pause, she said in a husky voice: "And also... you."

Her ears were red when she said this.

Even a single piece of candy could extend into so many details.

Liang Shi could never win against Xu Qingzhu. Many things, when recalled outside of the moment, could only be described as absurd.

Yet thinking of that absurdity made the corners of one's mouth turn up.

Even going to see Chen Liuying on a windy day didn't seem like an annoying thing.

Perhaps it was because she knew Chen Liuying was an unchangeable force majeure in the original novel, so she could have a bit more understanding of her actions.

But she wouldn't condone them.

They were all adults. If you made a mistake, you had to pay for it.

On the way to the Public Security Bureau, Liang Shi turned on the car stereo. The car weaved freely through traffic, passing other vehicles continuously.

The car happened to play a song called "Absurd."

It was just a bitter love song about unrequited love.

Liang Shi switched to an upbeat song and could even hum along to a few lines.

When the song reached its climax, Liang Shi realized she had heard this song before, a couple of days ago.

It was Xu Qingzhu's phone ringtone.

That day when the ringtone sounded, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were sitting on the bay window, watching the traffic below and the Yu River not far away.

Traffic flowed like shuttles on the Yu River Bridge, lights lit up on both sides of the bridge, and the water shimmered with reflections under the light.

Xu Qingzhu's tears were also illuminated brightly under the room's lights.

Sweat beaded on the tip of her nose as she clung to Liang Shi's neck without letting go.

It was during the heat period, and the nights were long.

In the end, even the bay window cushion was ruined.

After washing it in the washing machine, it became all wrinkled due to improper handling, so they had to replace it with a new one like the sofa cushion.

They even dirtied one of the plush toys placed on the bay window.

It had to be said, when Xu Qingzhu was nestled among that pile of plush toys, she looked both slender and radiant.

The water in the Yu River flowed past, catching the moonlight, but the scenery inside the room was even more beautiful than outside.

That day was when Liang Shi's pheromone release was at its most intense.

Perhaps because the scenery outside was so beautiful.

Xu Qingzhu's beauty had always been somewhere between pure and glamorous. Most of the time, she wasn't intimidating, but when she was angry, those clear deer-like eyes could make people tremble with fear, not daring to offend her.

But at times like those, her gaze was softer than the waters of the Yu River on a summer night.

Making one linger.

Liang Shi's pheromones intertwined with Xu Qingzhu's pheromones, spreading throughout the room, filling the entire space, making both of them lose some rationality.

Later, when bathing, there were several scratch marks on Liang Shi's waist that had actually broken the skin.

When hot water washed over them, Liang Shi felt a stinging pain.

Xu Qingzhu was clinging to her body and couldn't stand steadily at all. When Liang Shi complained about the scratch marks from her fingers, Xu Qingzhu looked up with those misty eyes, carrying a hint of grievance.

Her weak, powerless hand fell on her own shoulder, saying with both reproach and complaint: "Your strength is much greater than mine."

On her shoulder were red marks pressed by fingertips, which also looked painful.

Footnotes:

¹ JK style - Short for "Joshi Kousei" (女子高生), meaning "high school girl" in Japanese. JK fashion refers to Japanese schoolgirl-inspired fashion, typically featuring pleated plaid skirts, often paired with blazers or cardigans. It has become a popular fashion subculture in East Asia.

Chapter 136-3

Only after they finished bathing did Liang Shi get the bruise-healing ointment to apply on Xu Qingzhu.

While applying it, she even made Xu Qingzhu cry.

During those few days, Xu Qingzhu had an especially large amount of tears. She cried so much that before going to work the next day, Liang Shi had to ice her eyes.

After taking suppressants, an Omega's dependence on an Alpha would decrease.

But that was when there was no Alpha nearby. However, Liang Shi felt sorry for her, and aside from not feeding her meals, she wanted to do everything else for her. Even when Xu Qingzhu was going out and putting on shoes, Liang Shi would squat down to get her shoes from the shoe cabinet.

Xu Qingzhu felt embarrassed and wanted to do it herself.

But before she could even bend down, she had to hold her waist. Having been lying in bed for so long and having done so many things, even bending over had become a difficult, ache-inducing movement.

Liang Shi patted the top of her foot, "Don't try to be tough."

Xu Qingzhu glared at her, but without any intimidating effect whatsoever. Liang Shi just looked at her and smiled indulgently.

"I feel like I've become useless." Xu Qingzhu couldn't struggle free, so she stopped struggling and let Liang Shi put her shoes on for her, though her tone was slightly dejected.

But Liang Shi said: "Heat periods are a bodily characteristic. How does that make you useless?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Afraid she would feel bad, Liang Shi half-squatted there and said self-deprecatingly: "If we're talking about being useless, it should be someone like me, right? I haven't worked in so long. Teacher Xu takes suppressants and still goes to work. Truly..."

She paused, just finishing putting on Xu Qingzhu's shoes, gently setting her feet down, then looked up and said word by word: "A role model for our generation."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu stretched out her foot to kick her, but Liang Shi held it down.

Liang Shi's hand brushed past her ankle, stopping her: "Teacher Xu, you're wearing shoes."

Xu Qingzhu gave her a sidelong glance.

She had no choice but to give up.

She still remembered that night on the bay window, when the two of them just wanted to look at the scenery.

Looking at the melted snow on the road, looking at the water view of the Yu River—neither of them knew how things shifted in another direction.

Shifted in a direction neither could control.

There were clearly so many opportunities along the way to stop or turn back, but both of them let themselves indulge.

Liang Shi's sweat had soaked her temples. She asked Xu Qingzhu: "Is it beautiful outside?"

Xu Qingzhu's fingers were threaded through her hair, her voice choked: "Not as beautiful as you."

From midnight until dawn, when the distant sky turned the pale white of fish belly, they were both woken by the cold and only then returned to the bed.

Those sweet words Xu Qingzhu said during her heat period.

Even knowing they weren't entirely true, hearing them in the moment still made one's heart bloom with joy.

Liang Shi had never given Xu Qingzhu a cold face or gotten angry at her, even when she felt just a tiny bit that Xu Qingzhu was truly being unreasonable.

The next second, seeing her face and eyes, all the anger disappeared.

If she said one more coaxing word—just one.

Liang Shi would inevitably surrender quickly.

Facing Xu Qingzhu, how could she possibly get angry?

That day when the ringtone sounded, it was already late at night. Xu Qingzhu's crying had turned into soft sobbing, and Liang Shi's voice was also hoarse.

That ringtone broke the peaceful quiet of the room, ringing again and again.

Liang Shi was about to get up to fetch Xu Qingzhu's phone, but Xu Qingzhu wouldn't let her.

Before she could leave, Xu Qingzhu looked at her with grievance, "Jiejie~"

With her unique pacing and unique tone, she called out those two characters lingeringly, making one's heart tremble and legs go weak.

Almost without hesitation, Liang Shi turned back to the bay window.

Letting the ringtone sound in the room.

That ringtone rang again and again.

The next morning when they were both awake, Xu Qingzhu finally checked her phone and found it was an unknown number.

She called back, and it turned out the other party had dialed the wrong number.

It gave Liang Shi a false alarm—she had thought their absurdity had delayed something important for Xu Qingzhu.

When Liang Shi said this, Xu Qingzhu's brow furrowed slightly. Having just showered, her hair was still wet and hung down her back, covering her beautiful butterfly bones.¹

And the red marks on the side of her shoulder were very obvious.

Liang Shi sighed softly: "That's right. At the time, I was thinking it might be someone from the company looking for you."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu said faintly: "You were actually thinking about so much?"

Liang Shi: "...Huh?"

That astonished tone seemed to say—what else would I be thinking about?

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue: "Jiejie~"

Her wet hair brushed lightly across Liang Shi's leg like the wind. Liang Shi was about to say she would get her a towel to dry it, but Xu Qingzhu said leisurely: "It seems my charm isn't enough, that jiejie still had the mental energy to spare at times like that."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi was amused by her, "You don't know whether you have charm or not?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, her gaze clear, actually looking somewhat bewildered.

But if you looked carefully, you could see the craftiness in the depths of her eyes.

Liang Shi lowered her head and said by her ear: "These past few days I've nearly died with you in bed, and you still think you don't have charm?"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu laughed, the corners of her mouth curving into a brilliant arc as she raised her hand to cover her eyes full of mirth.

Xu Qingzhu turned and hugged her waist, nuzzling her head in her embrace.

Like a cat acting spoiled.

"Then do you not like it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "....."

A long time passed—so long that Xu Qingzhu, whose emotions were unpredictable during heat, got angry, angry enough to bite her abs through her clothes.

Only then did Liang Shi stroke her hair and say: "I like it."

During those few days, just drying her hair alone, Liang Shi had done it many times.

Who knows how many baths they took in a single day.

After sending Xu Qingzhu to the company, she didn't have much time to herself either. She had to reorganize things at home and tidy everything up.

Then go greet the people who knew about her coma, and very soon it would be time for Xu Qingzhu to get off work.

Footnotes:

¹ Butterfly bones (蝴蝶骨) - A Chinese term for the shoulder blades (scapulae). When they protrude slightly, they're said to resemble butterfly wings and are considered an attractive feature in Chinese beauty standards.

Chapter 136-4

On the way to pick up Xu Qingzhu from work, Liang Shi would always think.

Xu Qingzhu was already like this during her heat period now. If in the future her career reached its zenith, given her constitution, she would probably need three to five suppressant injections a day. And Xu Qingzhu was someone who was a bit afraid of needles.

Every time she had to inject a suppressant, she needed to be coaxed.

If Liang Shi wasn't there, she could still complete the injection, but the little expressions on her face were heartbreaking to watch.

When Liang Shi was there, or when Liang Shi helped her with the injection, coaxing was definitely required.

Liang Shi quite enjoyed it though.

The pharmacies here did have things like suppressant tablets and suppressant capsules, but their effectiveness was never as good as injectable suppressants.

Especially since suppressants came in different types.

However, whenever Xu Qingzhu had to go to work, Liang Shi would always put some in her bag.

All different kinds.

This made Xu Qingzhu complain that her bag was almost too full to hold anything else. Gone was the scent of the perfume she specifically sprayed—instead, it was all the smell of suppressants, which was uncomfortable to smell.

All Liang Shi could do was advise her, "Once you get through this period, it'll be fine."

Now she had made it through, and Liang Shi had gained a basic understanding of heat periods in this world.

To be precise, she had gained a basic understanding of Xu Qingzhu's heat period.

In the future when it happened again, she would have strategies to deal with it.

Liang Shi's car arrived at the entrance of the Municipal Public Security Bureau. Along the way, no matter what she looked at, she would think of Xu Qingzhu.

After turning off the engine, she shook her head to gather her thoughts, lest she keep being distracted by Xu Qingzhu.

They said that after marking, the Omega was the one most affected, but Liang Shi felt her own reaction was quite significant too.

At least in the past, she wouldn't think of Xu Qingzhu this frequently.

Even just driving, she could think of Xu Qingzhu several times.

Getting out of the car and being blown by the strong wind, she would also think of that day when Xu Qingzhu opened the window to feel the cold breeze.

And so on.

Clearly Xu Qingzhu wasn't by her side, yet Liang Shi felt that Xu Qingzhu was everywhere in her life.

Even after spending several days together, she had somewhat forgotten what the original Xu Qingzhu was like. She only remembered a little princess of a younger sister, a crybaby, whose eyes were like the main floodgate—open the gate with the slightest carelessness and water would come pouring out.

Her voice was no longer the cool, clear tone from before—it now carried a hoarse, husky quality.

Or when she cried until her voice was choked and hoarse, when pushed to her limit, she would also cry out "jiejie, please."

Liang Shi used to think she was someone without any mischievous tastes, but these past few days she realized she wasn't truly without desires, truly like a sage.

She suddenly realized that she was probably still thousands of miles away from being a sage.

Bullying someone until they couldn't speak, and bullying them until they cried out "jiejie"—these counted among her mischievous pleasures.

And Xu Qingzhu cooperated too. Occasionally willful, yet she would also succumb to instinct.

Especially since what Xu Qingzhu said was even more heart-stirring than what Liang Shi imagined in her mind.

Standing at the entrance of the Municipal Public Security Bureau, Liang Shi pinched her slightly feverish ears and smiled helplessly with her head lowered.

She probably needed a suppressant injection too.

Chapter 136-5

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Because Liang Shi was a party to the case, and had been unconscious the whole time.

During these days, it was Su Zhe and Liang Xinzhou who had been handling these matters. The person in charge of the case at the Municipal Public Security Bureau, upon learning that she had woken up, received word from above not to disturb her rest.

Instead, they waited until she had fully rested and came to them on her own initiative.

The incident from that day still needed her statement and testimony.

Chen Liuying had really kicked an iron plate this time.¹ Both Liang Xinzhou and Su Zhe were determined to send her in, even pushing toward the death penalty.

It was just that her level of crime was far from reaching the death penalty—at most, it would be life imprisonment.

Chen Liuying had already been detained for a long time, yet not a single relative had come to visit her, nor had any lawyer come to defend her.

She herself seemed to have given up too, lying inside sleeping all day.

Liang Shi first went to supplement her testimony and statement, then heard the police officer nearby say that the bureau was taking this case very seriously, so she should be able to get the outcome Liang Shi wanted.

At that moment, Liang Shi also thought about how the bureau chief here was a relative of Zhao Xuning.

So Zhao Xuning must have also contributed to this.

Liang Shi sent Zhao Xuning a message: 【Thanks.】

Zhao Xuning: 【...What are you going crazy about?】

Liang Shi:

"You have recalled a message."

Liang Shi felt that one should never get sentimental with a straight-laced queen.²

Upon hearing that Liang Shi wanted to see Chen Liuying, the police didn't stop her, only requesting that the entire meeting be recorded on video.

Liang Shi thought about it and nodded.

There wasn't much content that couldn't be heard anyway. What Liang Shi wanted to ask were just the same old things.

Seeing Chen Liuying again after just over half a month, she already looked nothing like she did in memory.

Chen Liuying was originally thin in order to look good on camera, though she had previously worked out and built a fit physique. These days, she probably hadn't been exercising anymore, her spirit dejected.

Without those expensive skincare products and toiletries here, her hair was dry like straw, and her face had broken out in acne.

Especially her forehead, which had a large patch of red spots.

Liang Shi casually looked her over a few times, then asked after a moment: "Why did you kidnap Xu Qingzhu that day?"

"Tired of hearing that." Chen Liuying said lazily.

At this point, Chen Liuying had long since given up on herself completely. During so many days of interrogation, she had confessed everything she could confess.

Now that Liang Shi came to ask, she couldn't be bothered to answer: "Ask something else."

Liang Shi paused.

After a while, Liang Shi asked again: "Were you acting under someone's orders?"

Chen Liuying was wearing handcuffs, and the slightest movement produced the sound of metal clashing. She laughed in a roguish manner: "Tired of hearing that too. Try another one."

Liang Shi: "....."

Chen Liuying was being very uncooperative, which was within Liang Shi's expectations.

But what Liang Shi most wanted to ask was—

"Was it a spur-of-the-moment decision or premeditated?"

Chen Liuying raised her eyebrow: "Does it make a difference?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Yes."

Chen Liuying thought about it, took the finger she had been using to pick her ear, brought it in front of her face and blew on it. Her whole demeanor seemed wicked.

The corner of her lips curved up slightly as she called out airily: "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi responded: "Hm?"

"Back when you were stealing my spotlight on set, when you were deliberately stealing my scenes, why didn't you ask yourself..." A flash of resentment passed through Chen Liuying's eyes, "...whether it was a spur-of-the-moment decision or premeditated?"

"So you simply hate me?" Liang Shi wasn't provoked by her words and asked back very calmly.

Chen Liuying scoffed lightly: "No."

Liang Shi frowned: "Then what else?"

Chen Liuying's tongue pressed against her teeth as she looked at Liang Shi coldly. After a long while, she finally said: "I really like Xu Qingzhu too."

"A woman like that." Chen Liuying said: "Who wouldn't want to have her? She's smart, capable, and beautiful. It's just a bit annoying that I fell at her hands. But..."

"Then why did you still hurt her?" Liang Shi seized the opportunity to ask: "You clearly knew she has PTSD."

Chen Liuying was stunned.

Her daze lasted for a long time, as if she couldn't answer Liang Shi's question.

The air was so quiet it seemed about to freeze.

Suddenly, Chen Liuying spoke, asking in bewilderment: "Yeah? Why?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Chen Liuying said: "It seems like the thought just appeared in my head—so I did it."

Footnotes:

¹ "踢到鐵板" (kicked an iron plate) - A Chinese idiom meaning to run into an immovable obstacle or to mess with the wrong person; similar to "kicking a hornet's nest" or "biting off more than one can chew."

² "直女逼王" - A slang term that roughly translates to a woman who appears very cool, aloof, and unemotional on the surface (often appearing "straight-laced" or serious), but this is just their natural demeanor. The term is often used affectionately to describe someone who isn't good at expressing emotions or being sentimental.